Quantum Benchmarking Initiative expands quest to separate hype from reality

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Quantum Benchmarking Initiative Expands Quest To Separate Hype From Reality
Quantum Benchmarking Initiative expands quest to separate hype from reality
New solicitation invites new entrants and approaches
March 10, 2026
As the quantum computing field accelerates,
DARPA's Quantum Benchmarking Initiative (QBI)
is expanding to capture its momentum.
Organizations that have not yet been funded by QBI are invited to join under a new Stage A Quantum Benchmarking Initiative Topic (QBIT), which builds on QBI's ongoing effort to rigorously determine whether any quantum computing architecture can achieve utility-scale operation — meaning its computational value exceeds its cost — by 2033.
Of particular interest are entrants with distinct approaches that have not yet been evaluated under QBI. Selected participants will enter Stage A, a six-month period in which they will describe a full system concept and provide evidence supporting its feasibility.
With this solicitation comes another shift for QBI:
Micah Stoutimore
is assuming the role of managing director for QBI, succeeding
founding program manager Joe Altepeter
who will support the transition prior to departing the agency.

Stoutimore has served as deputy program manager since the Initiative’s inception and supported related pilot efforts that helped shape the program’s evaluation framework. The transition is in keeping with DARPA tradition of mandatory limited tenure for program managers, a deliberate approach designed to keep programs fresh, continuously challenge assumptions, and ensure a steady infusion of new technical perspectives.

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In fact, it now seems likely that

someone

will build a utility-scale quantum computer by 2033, but it remains unclear exactly which team or teams might get across that finish line.

–

Micah Stoutimore,

managing director, Quantum Benchmarking Initiative QBI

“Joe built QBI from a concept into the world’s largest evaluation of quantum computing, and I’m grateful for the foundation he established,” said Stoutimore. “I’m honored to take on the role and continue steering the initiative as we expand the range of approaches under examination.”

Since its launch in mid-2024

, QBI has evaluated approaches from 20 commercial companies spanning a variety of qubit architectures. Eleven organizations have advanced to Stage B for deeper technical risk-reduction and development planning, while two performers from the

Underexplored Systems for Utility-Scale Quantum Computing (US2QC) pilot program

, have advanced to Stage C, working with the government to verify and validate system-level operation.

“Our renewed invitation to join Stage A reflects the rigor with which we evaluate every approach,” said Stoutimore. “Both QBI and the broader quantum computing field have advanced rapidly since our first call. In fact, it now seems likely that

someone

will build a utility-scale quantum computer by 2033, but it remains unclear exactly which team or teams might get across that finish line. We want to ensure we are assessing every viable pathway.”

Abstracts are due July 31, 2026, and full proposals for the Stage A QBIT are due Sept. 30, 2026. Interested parties can find further details within

the solicitation on SAM.gov

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Opportunity

DARPA-PA-26-02-02

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March 9, 2026

Deadline:

Sept. 30, 2026

Solicitation

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